UNIT 3 – FUNDAMENTALS OF WEB DIGITAL MEDIA DESIGN

ACTIVITY 3 – RESEARCH AND DESIGN PRINCIPLES AUDIT

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A. ACTIVITY OVERVIEW

This activity is a self-directed learning task designed to help you understand and apply fundamental design principles used in web and digital media design. Because this lesson is completed asynchronously, you will first research the principles using reliable references, then apply what you learned by auditing an actual website or digital media layout. The goal is not simply to define the terms, but to explain how design decisions affect communication, readability, visual appeal, and user experience.

B. LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Explain the basic principles of design using your own words.
- Identify how design principles are used in websites and digital media layouts.
- Support research findings with credible references.
- Analyze an actual digital media layout using appropriate design terminology.
- Evaluate the effectiveness of a design and recommend realistic improvements.

C. PART 1 – RESEARCH THE DESIGN PRINCIPLES

Before analyzing a design, research the eight principles below. Use reliable sources such as university learning resources, Adobe, Figma, design textbooks, educational websites, or other credible references. Do not copy definitions word-for-word. Read, understand, and explain each principle in your own words. Include at least one source/reference for every principle.

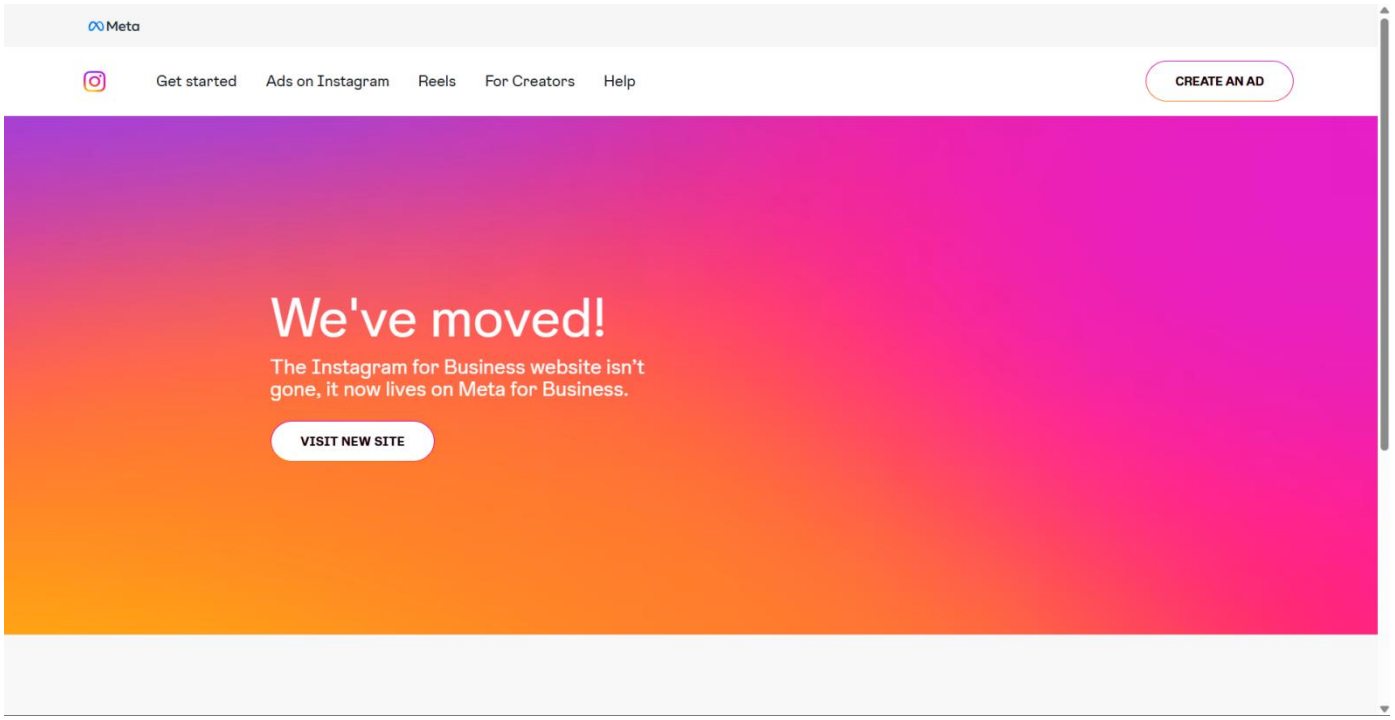
Design Principle	Definition in Your Own Words	Example in Web/Digital Media	Source / Reference
1. Balance	Balance is when the elements in a design are arranged so it does not look too heavy on one side.	Making posts usually balance pictures, text, icons, and other elements on the screen.	https://rwc.byu.edu/00000188-e4bc-d222-a7ea-eefd83280000/visual-design-pdf
2. Contrast	Contrast is when the two elements look different from each other that can stand out.	Some uses different colors and text sizes to make important buttons or information easier to notice.	https://designlab.wisc.edu/resources/design-tips-and-tricks/crap-principles/?
3. Alignment	Alignment means putting elements in an organized position so the design looks clean.	Aligns profile information, icons, captions, and other parts in an organized layout.	https://designlab.wisc.edu/resources/design-tips-and-tricks/crap-principles/?
4. Proximity	Proximity means putting things that are related close to each other.	A username, profile picture, caption, and post are placed near each other.	https://library.udel.edu/teaching-and-learning/tutorials/design-principles/?
5. Repetition	Repetition is using the same design elements again and again to make the design familiar.	It repeats the same icons, buttons, fonts, and layout style in different parts of the app.	https://ittrainingcontent.iu.edu/training/pgdlb/files/pc/incorporate-design-principles.html?
6. Visual Hierarchy	Visual hierarchy is likely arranging some things based on what the user should notice first.	An examples are, the photos or videos usually gets most attention before the caption.	https://www.adobe.com/express/learn/blog/8-basic-design-principles-to-help-you-create-better-graphics
7. White Space	White space is the empty space around design elements.	It leaves spaces between posts, text, and icons so it is easier to see.	https://web.mit.edu/6.813/www/sp18/classes/13-graphic-design/
8. Consistency	Consistency for me is keeping the same style and design throughout the whole site.	Keep using similar icons, colors, buttons, and layouts.	https://blogs.uoregon.edu/nicoledahmen/2015/01/05/design-principles/?

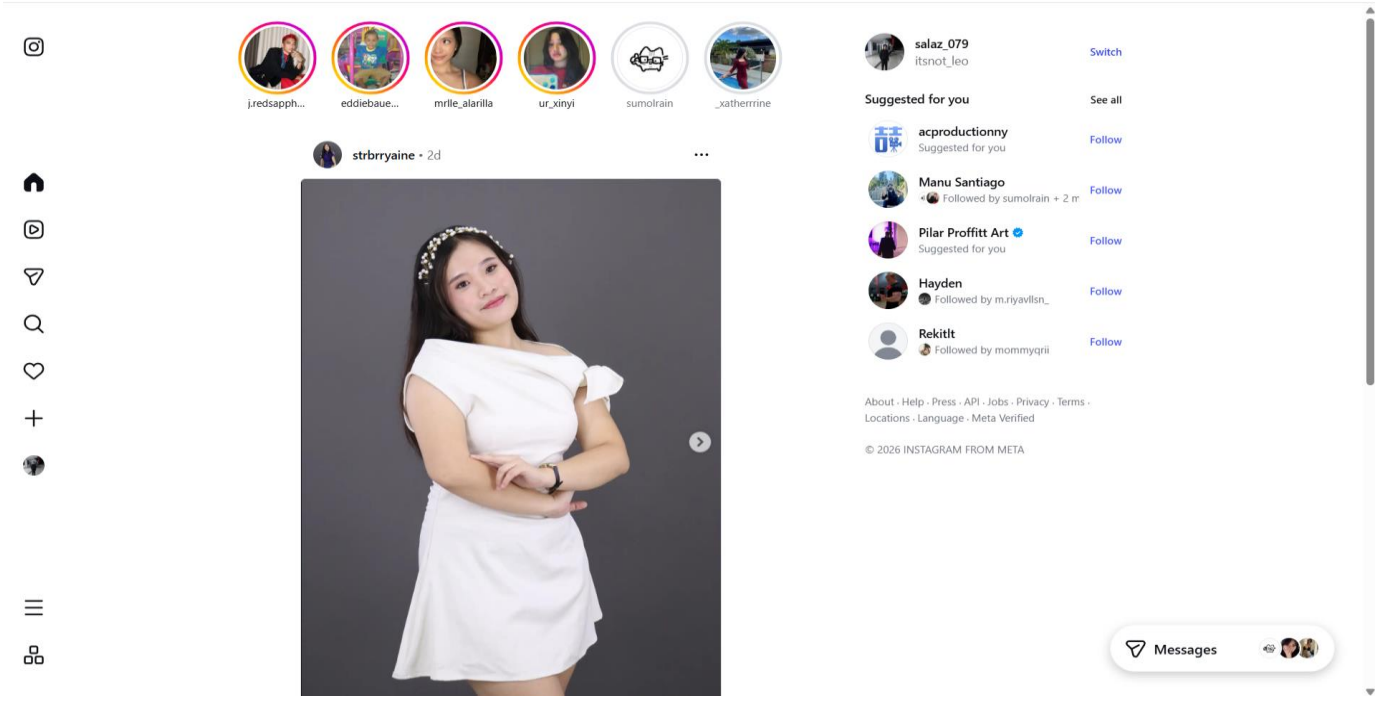
Suggested starting references: University design-learning resources, Adobe Learn, Figma Resource Library, and other credible educational sources. Always cite the specific page/resource you used.

D. PART 2 – DESIGN PRINCIPLES AUDIT

Choose ONE real website, social media page, online advertisement, digital poster, landing page, or other digital media layout. Take or attach a screenshot of the design you analyzed. Then use your research from Part 1 to complete the audit below.

- Choose a design that contains enough visual elements to analyze.
- Identify at least SIX of the eight principles. If a principle is not clearly present, explain why.
- Do not simply say “present” or “not present.” Point to a specific element in the design and explain its effect.
- Use your own observations and connect them to the concepts you researched.





Principle	Evidence in the Selected Design	How It Is Applied	Effect on Audience/User	Improvement (if needed)
1. Balance	It has different elements like photos, videos, captions, profile pictures and buttons.	These elements are placed in different areas of the screen so the page does not look too heavy.	It makes the app comfortable and easier to use.	Not needed
2. Contrast	It uses different colors, sizes, and backgrounds for buttons and text.	Important things can easy stand out from the rest of the screen.	Users can notice important buttons and information faster.	Some text on certain photos can be hard to see.
3. Alignment	Text, icons, profile information, and posts follow an organized layout.	Elements are placed in a good position on the screen.	It makes navigation easier to users.	Not needed
4. Proximity	The username, profile picture, caption, and post are close together.	Related information is grouped in the same area.	Users can understand what information belongs to a post.	Not needed
5. Repetition	Icons and interface elements are repeated throughout Instagram.	Similar buttons and symbols are used in different pages.	It helps users remember what this do.	Not needed
6. Visual Hierarchy	The main photo or video usually gets the attention.	Large visual content appears before smaller details.	Users immediately know what the post is about.	Sometimes ads can look too similar to normal posts.
7. White Space	There is space between posts, text, icons.	Empty space separates different sections of the app.	It makes the content easier to look.	Not needed
8. Consistency	Instagram uses repeated icons, buttons, fonts, and layouts.	The same visual style is used in many parts of the app.	Users can learn the app faster because things feel familiar.	Not needed

E. PART 3 – OVERALL DESIGN EVALUATION

1. What is the main purpose of the design you selected?

Answer: The main purpose of Instagram is to let people share photos, vid, stories, and other content with other people.

2. Who appears to be the intended audience?

Answer: The intended audience is mostly people who use social media, especially teenagers and young adults. It can also be used by older people, content creators, and organizations like schools and hospitals.

3. What design principle is used most effectively? Explain why.

Answer: I think visual hierarchy is used most effectively in Instagram. The photos and vids are usually the first thing users notice because they take a big part of the screen. After that, users can look at the username, caption, likes, comments, and other details. This helps users understand the post without being confused.

4. What design problem or weakness did you notice?

Answer: One weakness I noticed is that Instagram can sometimes it looks so crowded, specially when there are many icons, buttons, captions, and other information like sometimes its fake. Some sponsored posts can also look similar to normal posts, so it can be hard for users.

5. If you were the designer, what TWO changes would you make to improve the design?

Answer: First, I would make some of the buttons and information less crowded so the screen can look more clean. Second is I want to make sponsored content more easy to identify so users can quickly know if they are looking at an advertisement or in a random post.

6. How do the design principles help the digital media communicate its message more effectively?

Answer: The design principles help Instagram to organize more the content and make it easier for people to understand. Balance and alignment make the interface organized, while contrast and hierarchy help important things stand out.

F. PART 4 – SHORT REFLECTION

In 7–10 sentences, answer: “How did researching the design principles change the way you look at websites and digital media designs?” Your reflection should show what you learned and how you can apply it to your future digital media projects.

Before doing this activity, I mostly looked at websites and social media based on if they look nice or not. After researching the design principles, I noticed that there is actually many things happening in a design. I learned that balance can make a page look more organized and making easy to users. I also learned that contrast and visual hierarchy can help people notice important information first. When I look at IG now, I can see why the photos and videos are usually the main focus and also I notice how the buttons and icons are repeated so users can understand them easily. White space is also important because it stops the screen from looking too crowded. This activity helped me understand that good design is not only about making something beautiful. In my future digital media projects, I will think more about how the design can help people understand and make easy to use that even an older people is going to be happy.